



Web sites that you can change
from within your browser?
Here's how...

everyone's invited!

We've all seen Web sites with typos, incorrect grammar and just plain bad taste. Wouldn't you just love to fix all that you thought was wrong? Wouldn't it be great if every time you went to a Web site and found a '404 link', you could just create that page? Well, you can! No, not on every Web site you see, but on the Wiki Wiki Web.

What is the Wiki Wiki Web? No, it's not slang for the World Wide Web, *wiki* is actually Hawaiian for 'quick'. The Wiki Wiki Web was developed in 1995 by Ward Cunningham, who was going to call it Quick-Web, until he saw a bus called the Wiki Wiki Bus outside a Hawaiian airport. Ward's Wiki, or the Portland Pattern Repository Wiki, began as an interactive Web site for finding software development patterns, wherein any programmer could post his views or code that others could modify. Gradually, Ward's Wiki spawned many clones, and the Wiki community grew. The idea that one could change or improve what they saw—just by using their browser, was irresistible.

Wiki's uniqueness lies in its simplicity. For instance, to create a page all you need to do is string together two or more words into any page you edit. So, to create a page called 'My Page', just edit the text of any page, add in the word 'MyPage' (without

a space; capitalisation is important) and click Save. This automatically creates a page called MyPage, which you can now begin to edit.

So, even those with no knowledge of HTML, or experience of building Web sites, can re-format, add and delete pages. The program was written to be simple enough for a six-year old imp to a 60-year old grandpa to do everything on a Wiki.

Surprisingly, not many know about Wiki, though it has been around since 1995. Commonly asked questions are: Why? What's the point? How can it survive? How do you stop cyber vandals from destroying it?

Though it's normally sane to explain how something works before explaining why it works, Wiki is an exception to the rule; most people want to know, why it works, especially when anyone can delete, add, change, morph, mangle, etc., at will?

WikiWorks

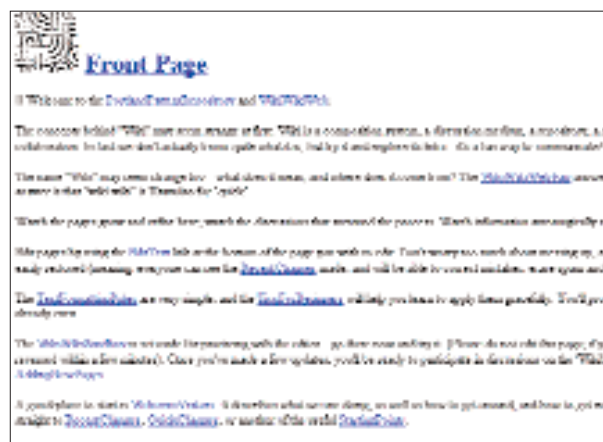
A Wiki is designed to give everyone a voice—whether it's a literary duel, or just a discussion about the weather. No matter what stand you take on what issue, as long as you're polite and make a valid point, no one will delete what you put up. Deleting a Wiki page, or even another author's content is just not done.

However, there are some bad apples to be sorted out. Once you become a Wikizen, you'll realise that those there for positive purposes, far outnumber the few odd vandals. Wiki's weaknesses are, in fact, its strengths. The very fact that anyone can edit any page can be a weakness—anyone can come along, and destroy a page with insults and expletives. However, these offences can be remedied almost instantaneously—by deleting or re-wording. Another boon is the Wiki ideology; sure it's fun to hack, crack, or any other 'ack' a place of high security, but what's the point in defacing a place that invites you with open arms?

Wikizens may give you a million reasons, but its existence since 1995 is conclusive proof of why a Wiki works.

To add a page Called *My Page*, just type in *My Page*?. Click on the ? to edit and thus create *My Page*?

Wiki is so easy to use, you can create pages without knowing any languages such as HTML



The first page of a Wiki is generally called Front Page or Start Page. These generally link to common pages such as Recent Changes, Welcome Visitors and the SandBox